When we came back from Toronto to Delhi, there were more than 5000 fans to receive us at one thirty in the morning at Delhi airport. The police were finding it difficult to control the crowd but I insisted that the team should wave to the fans before we left the airport. It was a grand homecoming. However, the satisfaction of beating Pakistan was short-lived, because within weeks we had lost a three-match ODI series in Pakistan.

In the second game, which we won, I remember telling our off-spinner Rajesh Chauhan how to play Saqlain Mushtaq's doosra ball. I gave him a mini-lecture for five minutes or so and told him to give the strike to Robin Singh, who was batting well at the other end. To my surprise, Rajesh ended up hitting a six in the last over and won us the game! However, we didn't really celebrate, as there were armed guards outside our hotel rooms for security reasons, something that made us uncomfortable and put a dampener on things. The deciding match of the series belonged to Ijaz Ahmed, who smashed our bowlers to all parts of the park on his way to 139, winning the game for Pakistan comfortably.

When we got back to Delhi this time having lost the series 1–2, the fans who had queued up just weeks earlier were nowhere to be seen. To cap it all, I also remember that those of us who were flying on to Mumbai were asked to pay excess baggage. I told my team-mates that we should just pay up and not argue.

The defeat in Pakistan added to the pressure that was building on me and an incident from the home Test series against Sri Lanka in November–December 1997 perhaps gives an indication of how I was feeling at the time. As captain, I was expected to deliver a winning performance in the three-Test contest. I had not done well as a batsman in the first two Tests, both of which ended in draws. To add to my misery, the second Test at Nagpur was a washout. A section of the media was having a go at me before the third Test in Mumbai, which started on 3 December 1997, and a lot was written about my poor form. It was a crunch situation and I needed to deliver both as batsman and captain.

On the first day I went in to bat with an hour left and was unbeaten on eight at the end of play. I had not batted at my best but at least I had survived. As the overnight not-out batsman, I needed to rest but as has often been the case with me, I couldn't sleep. By 10.30 p.m. I had started to feel very agitated. To get out of the stifling environment of the hotel, I